

The Precise Ask Script Builder

The complete tool from Don't Ask for a Round Number by Simon Gebhart.

This is the tool. It stands alone — if you skipped straight here, everything you need is on these pages, and the one-line version of the science behind it is this: precise numbers anchor better than round ones, but with an experienced manager a precise number *by itself* can read as bluffing, so every script below pairs the number with a one-line objective reason. Number plus reason. Never one without the other.

Three parts. Work them in order. Fifteen minutes, one sitting.

Part 1: The target-number calculator

You're turning a vague target into a precise anchor built from your own inputs.

Step 1 — Write your current base pay.

Current annual base: \$ _____

Step 2 — Write your raw target as a percentage.

Whatever you were planning — 8%, 10%, 15%. If you have no target yet, anchor it to evidence, not vibes: pull the going rate for your role and location from at least one source you can name out loud (a salary aggregator, your industry's published survey, your company's posted bands, recent postings for your role). Set your raw target where the market data and your scope say it should be.

Raw target: _____ %
Market source I can name: _____

Step 3 — Do the multiplication.

Current pay × (1 + raw target %) = raw figure: \$ _____

Step 4 — Add your line items.

List what specifically changed since your pay was last set, and attach a number to each:

Scope I absorbed (name it): _____ → worth roughly \$ _____
Months since last adjustment: _____
Measurable outcome I own (name one): _____

Adjust your raw figure by the line items. If the raw math lands on a round number, the line items will break the roundness for you — keep the real total instead of smoothing it.

Step 5 — The roundness check.

Look at your figure. If it ends in ,000 or ,500, you've rounded away your own math. Restore the real total.

MY PRECISE ASK: \$ _____

Sanity checks before you lock it:

- It's precise, not absurd. Hundreds-level precision (\$64,950) does the job; you don't need to go to the dollar.
- Every digit is explainable. If your manager asks "why that number?", each component has an answer. That's the whole point — the precision is the receipt of the math, not a costume over a guess.
- It's anchored to something external. If you deleted the market source, the number should still mostly survive on scope and tenure — but don't delete the market source.

Part 1, worked example

Here's the calculator run end to end, so you can see the shape of a finished one. The person and numbers are invented; your inputs replace them.

Maya earns **\$58,000** as a coordinator. Her pay was last set **26 months ago**. Since then she took over new-client onboarding when a colleague left, and the two salary sources she pulled for her role and metro both put the median around **\$64,000–\$66,000**.

- Step 1: current base = \$58,000.
- Step 2: raw target = 10%, source = the two aggregators she checked (she writes their names down, because she'll say one out loud).
- Step 3: $\$58,000 \times 1.10 = \textbf{\$63,800}$.
- Step 4: line items — onboarding scope, which she values at roughly \$1,100 based on what the posting for her departed colleague's role offered for that slice of work; 26 months since last adjustment. $\$63,800 + \$1,100 = \textbf{\$64,900}$.
- Step 5: roundness check — \$64,900 ends in a round-ish hundred but isn't a ,000/,500 figure; every digit traces to an input. She locks it. If her math had landed on \$65,000 exactly, she'd have kept the true unsmoothed total (say, \$64,950) rather than rounding up to the very number the mechanism says to avoid.

Her rationale line, built in Part 2: *"I'm asking for \$64,900 — that's benchmarked against the median for this role in our metro, and it reflects the client-onboarding work I've owned since last spring."*

Notice what the finished ask sounds like: not a demand, not a plea. A receipt.

Part 2: The rationale line-builder

One sentence. Fill in one of the three templates — pick the one where your evidence is strongest.

Template A — Market benchmark:

"I'm asking for [PRECISE NUMBER], based on the market rate for this role in our area — I benchmarked against [NAMED SOURCE]."

Template B — Scope:

"I'm asking for [PRECISE NUMBER] — that reflects the scope I've taken on since [DATE/EVENT], specifically [NAMED RESPONSIBILITY]."

Template C — Tenure plus outcome:

"I'm asking for [PRECISE NUMBER]. My compensation was last set [X] months ago, and since then [SPECIFIC MEASURABLE OUTCOME]."

Rules, non-negotiable:

- **One line.** Two facts maximum. A paragraph of justification reads as nerves.
- **Checkable facts only.** Named sources, dates, responsibilities. No adjectives about your work ethic.
- **Zero flexibility words.** No "but," no "open to," no "at least," no "would really help." Your fallback position does not appear in this sentence — or anywhere else in the conversation unless they counter.

MY RATIONALE LINE: _____

Part 3: The three scripts

Slot your number and rationale line into whichever channel fits your situation. In every script, you go first — the number is yours to name, not theirs to offer.

Script 1 — How to ask for a raise via email

Use email when you want the ask in writing, when your manager is remote, or when you think better with a keyboard. An email ask is a real ask — the first-offer effect held in email negotiations in the research, not just face-to-face. A common and effective pattern is using the email to open the conversation and set the anchor, then finishing live.

Subject: Compensation discussion

Hi [Manager],

I'd like to set up a short conversation about my compensation. I want to be direct about where I've landed so we can have a useful discussion:

[RATIONALE LINE — with your PRECISE NUMBER inside it.]

Since [DATE/EVENT], I've also [ONE SUPPORTING FACT — a second line item from your calculator].

Could we find 20 minutes this week or next? Happy to walk through how I got to that number.

Thanks,

[You]

Why it's built this way: the number appears in the email itself — you anchor in writing, before the meeting, so the live conversation starts from your figure. "Happy to walk through how I got to that number" signals the math exists without volunteering more. Nothing in the email hints at what you'd accept instead.

If a week passes with no reply, send one short nudge — and resist the urge to soften the original ask to make the silence stop:

Hi [Manager] — floating this back to the top of your inbox. Twenty minutes whenever works; the number and my reasoning are in the note below. Thanks.

The follow-up re-anchors by pointing back at the number without restating a weaker version of it. Silence is usually logistics, not verdict. Don't negotiate against yourself while waiting.

Script 2 — How to ask for a raise during a performance review

The review is the natural venue — compensation is already on the table — but it has a trap: your manager runs the agenda, and if you wait for the money portion to come to you, it arrives as *their* number. Go first anyway, at the transition from performance to future.

When the review turns to goals or the year ahead:

"Before we close, I want to raise compensation directly. Based on everything we just went over — [ONE-PHRASE CALLBACK to the strongest thing said in the review] — [RATIONALE LINE with PRECISE NUMBER]. What would it take to get there?"

Then stop. Let the silence sit. The callback move matters: your manager just spent thirty minutes telling you how you performed, and you're anchoring your number to *their own words* while they're still in the room. The rationale line arrives pre-agreed-with.

If the review opens with their number — "we've budgeted a 3% adjustment for your band" — don't haggle upward from it. Place your own anchor with its reason: "I appreciate that, and I want to share the homework I brought, because I arrived at a different number. [RATIONALE LINE with PRECISE NUMBER.]" The conversation is now about the gap between two documented positions, not about how far above 3% you can inch.

If they say the review cycle doesn't decide compensation: "Understood — who does, and what do you need from me to bring this number to them?" Your precise ask plus rationale is now the document that travels up the chain. This is exactly why it needed a named source and checkable facts — your manager has to be able to defend it to someone you'll never meet.

Script 3 — The in-person ask

For a scheduled one-on-one or a meeting you request. Book the meeting first — "I'd like 20 minutes to talk about my compensation" — so nobody is ambushed and you're not making the ask in a hallway.

Opening, verbatim if you want it:

"Thanks for making time. I'll be direct — I've done some homework on my compensation and I have a specific number. [RATIONALE LINE with PRECISE NUMBER.]"

Then stop talking. This is the hardest instruction in the book and the most important. The silence after your number feels endless from your side of the desk. It is not an emergency. It's your manager's mind adjusting from your anchor — in the

small steps your precise number forces. Every word you add while they think is a word that can only soften your position.

Responses to the three most likely replies:

- **"How did you get to that number?"** — This is the good outcome. It's an invitation to walk through Part 1. Market source, scope, tenure, line by line. You're now negotiating over your math, on your anchor.
- **"That's not in the budget right now."** — "What would need to be true for it to be? I'd like to agree on a timeline and what you'd need to see from me." You're converting a no into a documented plan — the last chapter covers this.
- **A counter below your number.** — Don't accept in the room and don't slash your ask in the room. "I appreciate that. Help me understand the gap between that and [YOUR NUMBER] — which part of my case doesn't land?" You defend the components, not your feelings.

The five ways people break this tool

A pre-flight checklist. Each mistake undoes one of the mechanisms the tool is built on.

1. **Rounding the final number "to keep it simple."** You just rebuilt the coarse adjustment scale the precision was there to prevent. Keep the real total.
2. **Saying the number and then explaining for two minutes.** One line. A flood of justification reads as nerves, and somewhere in minute two you'll leak your fallback.
3. **Waiting to be asked.** "What were you thinking?" means you're about to become the second offer. Bring the number up yourself, early.
4. **Softening in the silence.** "...or, you know, whatever's possible" — spoken four seconds after a perfectly good anchor — converts your ask into a range with a floor of zero. The silence belongs to them, not you.
5. **A precise number you can't explain.** If any digit has no line item behind it, an experienced manager's follow-up question will find it. The precision must be the receipt of real math — that's the entire difference between prepared and bluffing.

Do this now: Fill in the worksheet — all three parts. Your precise number from the calculator. Your rationale line from the builder. Circle which of the three scripts matches your situation, and fill in its blanks so it's word-for-word ready. Then put a date on it: pick a day this month for the ask, and if it's the email script, pick the day you hit send. A finished worksheet with no date is a rehearsal. The date makes it a plan.

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The full guide: amazon.com/dp/BOH7JNX25P